

Military struck by virus

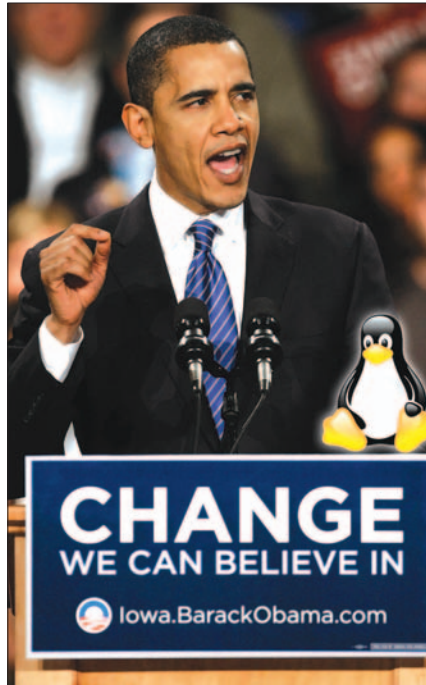
That very familiar doomsday scenario of planes falling out of the sky would nearly have been a reality thanks to the “Conficker” virus. Recently, French fighter aircrafts were unable to download their flight plans after databases were infected by the virus. Microsoft had warned that Conficker, transmitted through Windows, was attacking computer systems in October last year. However, it seems that the French military ignored the warning and failed to install the necessary patches. They managed to contain the infection by shutting down their entire communication system and resorting traditional forms of communication such as telephone, fax and snail-mail! The attack on the system, however, is not believed to be specific or with malicious intent.

Conficker surfaced sometime in October '08 and has been quite a pain for Microsoft. Also known as “Downandup” and “Kido”, it is one of the worst computer threats in years, infecting more than 10 million systems worldwide. Microsoft has even put up a bounty of \$250,000 (Rs. 12.35 million) on the Conficker's authors head! However, this is not the first time such a strategy has been used. In 2005, Microsoft paid the same amount to two people for identifying the man behind the Sasser worm. As it turned out, it was a teenager by the name of Sven Jaschan. Even if this tactic has proved effective in the past, speculation suggests that Microsoft won't get far this time as it's believed the creator of Downandup is from a part of the world that is soft on Cybercrime such as Russia, Ukraine, or Romania. Therefore, even if he were identified, conviction would be difficult. What Microsoft probably didn't think about is that the designer of the code himself might jump at the bounty. This might spark off a ridiculous trend where malicious code writers start looking at the Bounty as prize money!



“Change” to open source

In an open letter to the Obama administration, a group of software vendors is encouraging the US Government to switch over to open source. The letter tries to impress upon the new president, the benefits of open source by likening open source to Obama's campaign philosophy of *hope, change, and openness*.

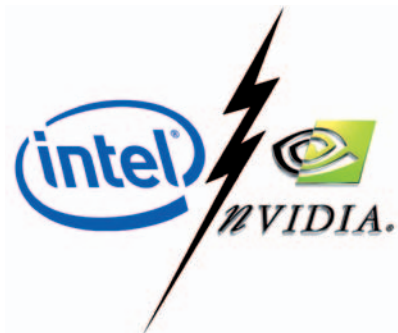


It's curious to note that these vendors are actually commercial vendors and specifically plugging TriSano – an open source, citizen-focused surveillance and outbreak management system for infectious disease, environmental hazards, and bio-terrorism attacks. These proponents of open source are not like your regular Linux fan boys. They're entrepreneurs who appreciate the cost efficacy of collaborative development. However, it turns out that the US administration has been using open source for quite some time now, especially the Department of Defense. Linux and other open source technologies have been used by the DoD in a wide range of deployment areas, including the Army Future Combat Systems program and the Land Warrior program.

The obvious advantages that the administration hopes to gain in is terms of lesser risk of vendor lock-in and lower IT infrastructure costs. The same advantages can be leveraged into servicing other areas such as schools and other public utilities.

Intel v/s NVIDIA

There seems to be some sort of a legal battle brewing between chip manufacturing rivals Intel and NVIDIA. Why are they rivals you might ask. Well if we are to go by NVIDIA's take on the chip manufacturing business, then CPU manufacturing is a decaying business and the GPU (graphics processing unit) is the new heart and soul of the the PC. In fact, NVIDIA believes that this whole law suit by Intel is nothing but a last ditch effort by processor manufacturer to protect precisely this decaying CPU business. The ruckus is being raised because Intel recently sued NVIDIA claiming that the existing licence agreement between them does not allow NVIDIA to design chipsets for CPUs with integrated memory controllers such as the Nehalem. NVIDIA, on the other hand, is confident that it does. So like all disputes in the western world, this one, too, is being settled by a court. Mind you, both the companies have had agreements in place for a long time that allow NVIDIA to make chip-sets for the processor making giant. Emphasising that NVIDIA will not back down, the CEO Jen-Hsun Huang was quoted saying, “this case is about the future and NVIDIA's ability to continue to innovate and make a difference in the industry by creating its own products, not just those



that Intel allows it to create”. With sales of desktop processors down by 18 per cent in the last quarter, and those of graphics cards down by almost 35 per cent, this sort of in-fighting isn't going to help either of the companies.

Meanwhile, the companies are fighting battles elsewhere too. Intel is trying to launch products by defining newer product categories such as netbooks and the latest one MID. MIDs are mobile internet devices; basically, portable gadgets that can replicate the PC experience. Intel is trying to perfect a new platform technology called Moorestown for MIDs that will negate the power draining nature of processors. Similarly, NVIDIA is banking on the Tegra 600 and Ion chips to win in this segment.